

History of English Literature - Important MCQs (Part 7)

Page 32 - Other Poets of Chaucer's Age (Part 1)

Q1. If Wyclif was 'the morning star of the Reformation', what may Chaucer be called?

- A. The morning star of the Renaissance
- B. The father of English drama
- C. The creator of the English novel
- D. The last of the medieval bards

Answer: A

Q2. What is described as a specially charming feature of Chaucer's poetry?

- A. Its complex theological arguments
- B. Its fresh out-of-doors atmosphere and love of nature
- C. Its detailed maps of the medieval world
- D. Its focus on inner psychological turmoil

Answer: B

Q3. What kind of metre did Chaucer adopt, abandoning the Old English irregular lines and alliteration?

- A. Free verse
- B. Haiku
- C. The French method of regular metre and end-rhymes
- D. Blank verse without rhyme

Answer: C

Q4. Who was Chaucer's chief rival in poetry?

- A. William Shakespeare
- B. John Gower
- C. John Wyclif
- D. William Langland

Answer: B

Q5. How does Chaucer refer to John Gower in his dedication of Troylus and Cryseyde?

- A. The 'moral Gower'
- B. The 'merry Gower'

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- C. The 'tragic Gower'
- D. The 'genius Gower'

Answer: A

Q6. How is Gower's writing style characterized in comparison to Chaucer's?

- A. Much more vivacious and charming
- B. Extremely voluminous, learned, careful, but mostly hopelessly dull
- C. Only written in short, lyric poems
- D. Highly comedic and lighthearted

Answer: B

Q7. What was Gower's attitude regarding the best medium (language) for his poetry?

- A. He immediately chose English like Chaucer
- B. He wrote exclusively in Latin
- C. He found it hard to make up his mind, writing three long poems in three different languages
- D. He invented a new language

Answer: C

Q8. Which of Gower's poems was written in English, challenging comparison with Chaucer?

- A. Speculum Meditantis
- B. Vox Clamantis
- C. Confessio Amantis
- D. Handlyng Synne

Answer: C

Q9. What is the main subject matter of Gower's 'Confessio Amantis'?

- A. The history of the English kings
- B. Tales introduced to illustrate the evils wrought by the seven deadly sins
- C. A detailed account of Wat Tyler's rebellion
- D. A translation of the Bible

Answer: B

Q10. What was Gower's view of the social conditions of the time?

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- A. He thought they were perfectly fine
- B. He took a very gloomy view, often criticizing the clergy
- C. He was a radical revolutionary
- D. He only cared about romantic love

Answer: B

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Page 33 - Other Poets of Chaucer's Age (Part 2)

Q1. Where did Gower stand politically, despite his criticisms?

- A. He was a radical revolutionary like Wat Tyler
- B. He was a follower of Wyclif and the Lollards
- C. He was a strong conservative
- D. He was a French sympathizer

Answer: C

Q2. Who is the third writer of this age, described as essentially a poet of the people?

- A. John Gower
- B. John Barbour
- C. William Langland
- D. Harry Bailly

Answer: C

Q3. What kind of life did William Langland seemingly live?

- A. A life of wealth and courtly favor
- B. A life as a powerful church prelate
- C. A life of poverty and struggle
- D. A life as a successful merchant

Answer: C

Q4. What is the title of William Langland's enormous allegorical poem?

- A. The Brus
- B. The Vision of William Concerning Piers the Plowman
- C. Confessio Amantis
- D. Vox Clamantis

Answer: B

Q5. How is Langland's 'Vision' described in terms of literary art?

- A. A perfect masterpiece of structure
- B. Rambling, confused, and almost formless

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- C. A concise, perfectly rhymed sonnet sequence
- D. A highly polished courtly romance

Answer: B

Q6. What does Langland boldly attack in his poem under the device of a dream?

- A. The French monarchy
- B. The use of the English language
- C. Social and ecclesiastical abuses, greed of the clergy, and tyranny of the high
- D. Chaucer's poetry style

Answer: C

Q7. How is Langland's spirit described?

- A. Aristocratic and conservative
- B. Genial, tolerant, and easy-going
- C. Strikingly puritan and democratic
- D. Apathetic to social issues

Answer: C

Q8. How does the language and style of Langland's work compare to Chaucer's?

- A. It is exactly the same
- B. It is far more rustic and old-fashioned
- C. It is much more modern and French-influenced
- D. It is written completely in Latin

Answer: B

Q9. What poetic principle does Langland's poem adhere to, making it the last important poem written this way?

- A. French end-rhyme
- B. Iambic pentameter
- C. The Anglo-Saxon principle of alliteration
- D. Blank verse

Answer: C

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Q10. Who is considered the real father of Scottish poetry and wrote 'The Brus'?

- A. John Gower
- B. William Langland
- C. Robert Bruce
- D. John Barbour

Answer: D

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Page 34 - Prose of Chaucer's Age

Q1. How are Chaucer's own few prose writings described in importance?

- A. They are his greatest achievements
- B. They are not important
- C. They revolutionized science
- D. They are still used as textbooks today

Answer: B

Q2. What did Wyclif's controversial pamphlets help to show regarding the vernacular?

- A. That English was useless for theology
- B. The capabilities of English at a time when Latin was deemed the only fitting vehicle for theology
- C. That French should be used in church
- D. That nobody could read English

Answer: B

Q3. What is considered the great prose work of this period?

- A. The Travels of Sir John Maundeville
- B. A Treatise on the Astrolabe
- C. The Anglo-Saxon Chronicle
- D. The Vision of Piers Plowman

Answer: A

Q4. What does 'The Travels of Sir John Maundeville' purport to give an account of?

- A. A journey across the Atlantic Ocean
- B. Wanderings in the Holy Land and the far east
- C. A political tour of France
- D. A scientific expedition to the North Pole

Answer: B

Q5. What is now established regarding the alleged author, Sir John Maundeville?

- A. He was a great explorer
- B. He was actually the King in disguise

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- C. No such person ever existed
- D. He was a close friend of Chaucer

Answer: C

Q6. From what language is 'The Travels of Sir John Maundeville' actually a translation?

- A. Latin
- B. French (from a certain Jean de Bourgogne)
- C. Italian
- D. Greek

Answer: B

Q7. Instead of a genuine record of travel, what is 'The Travels of Sir John Maundeville' really?

- A. A compilation of fabulous stories out of Pliny, Marco Polo, and others
- B. A completely original fantasy novel
- C. A strict geographical textbook
- D. A political allegory

Answer: A

Q8. Which of the following is an example of the marvelous things described in Maundeville's book?

- A. The invention of the steam engine
- B. A weeping crocodile and rocks of adamant that drew nails out of ships
- C. Accurate maps of the Americas
- D. The exact height of Mount Everest

Answer: B

Q9. Despite being a translation and a fabrication, what place does 'The Travels of Sir John Maundeville' keep?

- A. It is the best-selling book of all time
- B. It is the first English prose classic
- C. It is the only book from the 14th century to survive
- D. It is used as a modern travel guide

Answer: B

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Q10. According to the table, in what year did the Hundred Years' War with France begin?

A. 1327

B. 1338

C. 1346

D. 1348

Answer: B

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Page 35 - Table of the Age of Chaucer

Q1. According to the table, when was the Battle of Crecy fought?

- A. 1338
- B. 1346
- C. 1356
- D. 1381

Answer: B

Q2. During what years did the Black Death occur according to the table?

- A. 1327-1330
- B. 1348-1349
- C. 1380-1381
- D. 1399-1400

Answer: B

Q3. When was the Battle of Poitiers fought?

- A. 1346
- B. 1356
- C. 1381
- D. 1399

Answer: B

Q4. When was the Boke of the Duchesse written?

- A. 1360
- B. 1369
- C. 1383
- D. 1393

Answer: B

Q5. Over what span of years did Langland write his 'Vision'?

- A. 1340-1360
- B. 1362-1390

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C. 1380-1400

D. 1390-1410

Answer: B

Q6. When did Wat Tyler's Rebellion take place?

A. 1348

B. 1381

C. 1399

D. 1400

Answer: B

Q7. In what year did the official condemnation of Wyclif's opinions occur?

A. 1380

B. 1382

C. 1399

D. 1408

Answer: B

Q8. From what year onward did Chaucer begin working on the Canterbury Tales?

A. 1369

B. 1380

C. 1385 onward

D. 1399 onward

Answer: C

Q9. In what year did Henry IV ascend the throne?

A. 1377

B. 1381

C. 1399

D. 1400

Answer: C

Q10. In what year did both Chaucer and Langland die?

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A. 1381

B. 1399

C. 1400

D. 1408

Answer: C

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Page 36 - From Chaucer to Tottel's Miscellany (Part 1)

Q1. What period follows the brilliant beginning made by Chaucer in English literature?

- A. An immediate golden age
- B. A long barren period in its history (the 15th century)
- C. The Romantic era
- D. The Victorian age

Answer: B

Q2. The lack of great books for a hundred years after Chaucer might simply be due to what?

- A. A ban on printing presses
- B. A dearth of literary talent
- C. All writers moving to France
- D. The complete loss of the English language

Answer: B

Q3. Was the fifteenth century in England considered an age of great men in any field of activity?

- A. Yes, it was the greatest century for English leaders
- B. No, it is noteworthy that it was not an age of great men in any field
- C. Yes, but only in military strategy
- D. Yes, but only in religious leadership

Answer: B

Q4. Even when talent exists, what does it depend upon for its expression?

- A. Favourable conditions
- B. Pure luck
- C. Royal blood
- D. A university degree

Answer: A

Q5. What happened to efforts toward religious reform after Wyclif?

- A. They were immediately successful
- B. They were supported by the Pope

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- C. Religion degenerated, and persecution was used to stamp out reform efforts
- D. The entire country became Protestant overnight

Answer: C

Q6. How did religious persecution affect intellectual life?

- A. It encouraged open debate
- B. It checked the free movement of thought
- C. It caused an explosion of philosophical writing
- D. It had no effect on intellectuals

Answer: B

Q7. The country was distracted by political conflicts culminating in what struggle?

- A. The Hundred Years' War
- B. The thirty years' struggle for power between the Houses of York and Lancaster
- C. The Crusades
- D. The English Civil War

Answer: B

Q8. What is another name for the struggle between the Houses of York and Lancaster?

- A. The War of the Worlds
- B. The Wars of the Roses
- C. The Peasant's Revolt
- D. The Great War

Answer: B

Q9. What happened to the old order of feudalism during the Wars of the Roses?

- A. It was greatly strengthened
- B. It was severely shaken at its foundations as many nobles were killed
- C. It was exported to France
- D. It was formally established as law

Answer: B

Q10. What other factor is mentioned as contributing to the unproductiveness of the 15th century?

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- A. The low state of education
- B. Too much wealth among the peasantry
- C. An obsession with sports
- D. Overpopulation

Answer: A